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New Report Reveals Unprecedented Solar Power Growth in U.S.

CHAZ WILKE ([HTTPS://SOLARMEHOME.COM/AUTHOR/CHAZW/](https://solarhome.com/author/chaZW/)) / MARCH 20, 2015 ([HTTPS://SOLARMEHOME.COM/NEW-REPORT-REVEALS-UNPRECEDENTED-SOLAR-POWER-GROWTH-IN-U-S/](https://solarhome.com/new-report-reveals-unprecedented-solar-power-growth-in-u-s/)) / [LEAVE A COMMENT \(HTTPS://SOLARMEHOME.COM/NEW-REPORT-REVEALS-UNPRECEDENTED-SOLAR-POWER-GROWTH-IN-U-S/#RESPOND\)](https://solarhome.com/new-report-reveals-unprecedented-solar-power-growth-in-u-s/#RESPOND)



In the recently released U.S. Solar Market Insight 2014 Year in Review, GTM Research and the Solar Energy Industries Association (SEIA) revealed that U.S. solar installers added an unprecedented solar capacity of 6,201 megawatts in 2014 (<http://bit.ly/1bkcgW6>). The report reveals that this is a growth of 30 percent over 2013.

This commitment to clean energy represents nearly \$18 billion in new investments, the report says. Homes, schools, businesses and utilities have all embraced solar power in increasing numbers. Officials said that 2014 proved that United States is one of the world's leading adopters of solar power.

Obstacles Remain

Nonresidential solar panel installations dropped 6 percent in 2014. The report cites reasons "ranging from tight economics to difficulty financing small commercial installations." This is coupled with the news that the federal tax incentive, the 33 percent investment tax credit, is scheduled to expire at the end of 2016. This may leave business owners with the hard decision to shoulder the upfront burden of solar panel installation in the near

future.

Also, “Growth remains driven primarily by the utility solar PV market (<http://bit.ly/1DGOU9e>), which installed 1.5 GW in Q4 2014, the largest quarterly total ever for any market segment,” says a summary of the GTM and SEIA report. This means that municipalities are still outpacing residential and business solar panel installations for the time being. While this isn’t necessarily bad news, there will likely be a finite amount of resources utility companies will invest in clean energy. It remains uncertain exactly when this threshold will be met.

Indications on Market Direction

Even though the report cites a few obstacles, the overall takeaway indicates that the U.S. is rapidly growing its solar strength. The report indicated “the U.S. PV market—which does not include concentrated solar plants—has witnessed a fourfold expansion (<http://bit.ly/1HcQr81>), from an estimated \$3 billion in 2009 to \$13.4 billion last year,” reports Scientific American.

On the employment front, SEIA’s president Rhone Resch released a glowing statement about the solar industry: “Today the U.S. solar industry has more employees than tech giants Google, Apple, Facebook and Twitter combined,” he said.

Takeaway

Predicting the direction of any market is merely speculation, but the numbers from 2014 don’t lie. The solar industry continues to grow. From \$3 billion in 2009 to \$13.4 billion, the solar PV market in the U.S. has performed well to say the least.

Shayle Kann, senior vice president at GTM research delivers a promising diagnosis for 2015. “This growth should continue throughout 2015 thanks to falling solar costs, business model innovation, an attractive political and regulatory environment and increased availability of low-cost capital.”

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